Drought and Australian ecosystems

Drought describes a time of abnormally low rainfall in a certain area, when there is not enough water to meet normal needs. Australia is often affected by drought. Sometimes a drought can last for many years.

If water supplies in an ecosystem are low for a long time, plants wither and die. This causes **food shortages** for all the living things that rely on those plants for food, and loss of shelter for some animals. Eventually, the animals that do not have enough food stop breeding and may die out. The food web of an ecosystem can be harmed in this way. In places where drought has gone on for a long time, some ecosystems never recover.

☞ **1** Solve the puzzles to complete the list of words about drought.

a) __ __ __ __ __ __ __ This word means 'a time when there is unusually low rainfall' and begins with the letter that comes after 'c' in the alphabet.

b) __ __ __ __ __ __ __ __ __ This name of a country has 'u' as its second letter.

c) __ __ __ This word means the opposite of 'live'.

d) __ __ __ __ __ __ __ This word means 'a place to get protection from the weather'.

e) __ __ __ __ __ __ __ __ This word has 'ee' in it and means 'reproducing'.

f) __ __ __ __ __ __ __ This word means 'a particular type of living creature' and starts and ends with 's'.

2 Complete the passage by writing your answers from Question 1 into the correct spaces.

A time of unusually low rainfall in a place is called a _____. Some parts of _____ are frequently affected by drought. Plants can _____ if a drought lasts a long time. When plants are lost, animals that need plants for food and _____ are affected. If they do not have enough food, animals may stop _____. This makes it more likely that the _____ will become endangered or die out.

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